IT IS SETTLED

From God's Perspective

a Journey Through Romans

JOHN WRY

It Is Settled

From God's Perspective

A Clear and Simple Tour of the Book of Romans

"Because of the anguish of His soul,

He will see it and be satisfied..."

Isaiah 53:11

John Wry

First edition

2026

Scripture quotations taken from the NEW AMERICAN STANDARD BIBLE®,

Copyright © 1960, 1962, 1963, 1968, 1971, 1972, 1973, 1975, 1977, 1995

by The Lockman Foundation.

Used by permission.

Purpose of this Book

This book was written to help the reader understand a simple, yet often misunderstood, truth:
what God has already resolved does not need to be resolved by us.
Many believers live as if their standing before God is fragile, uncertain, or dependent on continuous performance. The message of Romans presents a very different picture: one in which God acts decisively, justly, and finally.
This book does not pretend to be technical or academic.
It is written in clear and thoughtful language so that the reader can follow the flow of Paul's message without prior theological training.
Romans will be treated as a **message to be understood**, not just verses to be quoted.

How to Use This Book

Read calmly
Follow the argument as it unfolds
Allow conclusions to emerge from the text
Resist the temptation to insert assumptions
The goal is not to tell you *what to think*, but to help you see **what to do.**
the text is really saying.

PRELUDE

Reality Doesn't Start With Us

Most people live as if reality
It will begin where your thoughts begin.
Or where their emotions begin.
Or where your questions begin.
And that feels natural... until we notice how fragile it is.
Because if reality begins with me, then reality
it changes when I change. It changes with my mood.
It changes with my mental clarity. It changes with my energy.
It changes with my last fall or my last "good day".
But the Bible does not allow for that starting point. The Bible begins with a silent but absolute affirmation: **God is**.

> *"In the beginning God..." - Genesis 1:1*

God is. Not as a conclusion we reach, but as a reality that precedes us. Before the human being interprets something, God already exists, already acts, already speaks. What was not seen (God) established all that was made (us).

> *"... so that what is seen was not made of visible things." - Hebrews 11:3*

Here's a question worth asking slowly:
Am I willing to accept that reality is true before I understand it?
Because that's what revelation entails.
Scripture exists because God is not silent.
Not because human beings deserve it, nor because human beings have successfully sought it, but because God decided to make himself known.

> *"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things revealed belong to us and to our children forever..." - Deuteronomy 29:29*

And when God reveals himself, one thing is established: truth is not constructed from human experience; it is declared by divine authority.

> *"I have known of Thy testimonies long ago, that Thou hast founded them forever." - Psalm 119:152*

God Speaks Before We Respond.

That's not just a pious idea. It is the foundation of objectivity.

If we reverse that order, everything that follows becomes unstable. Even beautiful words like "grace," "faith," and "assurance" become slippery. Grace begins to sound like opinion. Faith begins to sound like effort.
Security is beginning to sound like presumption. And then, without realizing it, we end up living not under revelation... but under interpretation.
Isn't that the root of a lot of our anxiety
spiritual?
Not that we don't know what the Bible says... but we do not know what authority he has in the face of what we feel.
God is not a piece in the world. It is the world's point of reference.
Saying "God is the center" may sound like a religious cliché.
But in Romans—and throughout the Bible—that phrase has a concrete meaning: God is not an accessory to improve life. God is the one who defines what is real, true, and good.

> *"... From eternity to eternity, You are God." - Psalm 90:2*

This means that God does not enter my story to collaborate with my plans. My story exists within His reality.

> *"For from Him, through Him, and to Him are all things." - Romans 11:36*

What if God is not one perspective among others, but the criterion of all perspectives?

We usually think of God as one point of view among many: a religious opinion that competes with other worldviews. But the Bible proposes something radically different: that God is not simply a perspective from which we look at reality, but the foundation that defines what is true, what is real, and what is right in all perspectives. If this is so, then truth is not determined by comparing human opinions, but by aligning with what God has revealed. In that case, our experiences, emotions, and reasoning are not the starting point, but must be evaluated in the light of God, who does not observe reality from within it, but establishes and sustains it. So my experience cannot sit as a judge on His word. My conscience cannot have the last word. My performance cannot define my position.

> *"For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways,'*
> *declares the LORD." - Isaiah 55:8*

When we say that God is not just another perspective, but the criterion of all perspectives, we are not denying human experience. The experience is still real, but it is no longer the final point of reference. Instead of ruling the truth, it is placed within something greater.
The same goes for feelings. They are not eliminated or despised. They are real, powerful, and meaningful. But they do not define reality by themselves. They need to be interpreted in the light of something stable, because they change, fluctuate, and sometimes contradict what is true.

Nor is conscience annulled. Consciousness continues to function, but it no longer presents itself as the supreme authority. It is subjected to a greater reference that evaluates, corrects and shapes it. When conscience becomes the final judge, it ends up being fragile or accusatory. When it is aligned with a greater truth, it can rest. In this framework, God does not compete with experience, feelings, or conscience. He gives them meaning, direction and rest, because He is not just another voice within human dialogue, but the point from which all dialogue is evaluated.

An Example of 1 John

When we affirm that God is not one perspective among others, but the yardstick of all perspectives, **1 John** shows us exactly how that works in real life. John
He does not deny experience; in fact, he begins by appealing to it: *what we have heard, what we have seen, what we have touched*.
But that experience does not govern truth. **It is subordinate to the message that God has revealed**: "God is light." The experience is real, but it is **placed** under a larger reference.
The same goes for feelings. John does not ignore what people feel or affirm internally ("if we say..."), but neither does he grant them final authority. Feelings do not define reality; **are evaluated**. That is why John can say: "In this we know..." Knowledge does not arise from emotional intensity, but from alignment with what God has said and made known. Nor is consciousness discarded. John recognizes that the heart can accuse or disturb, but he immediately introduces a higher reference: **God is greater than our heart**. Conscience continues to speak, but it is no longer the supreme judge. It is **subjected** to a greater truth that interprets and corrects it. Thus, 1 John does not invite us to turn off experience, feelings, or consciousness, but to **reorder them**. God does not enter as one more voice into the interior dialogue of the believer; it enters as the **criterion** that gives meaning, stability and rest to everything else. That is why John can say with such certainty: "We know that...". Not because the believer feels secure, but because God's revealed truth sustains that assurance.

How Does Human Life Really Work?

Every life has a center.
Even those who say "I don't believe in anything" live from something they consider more trustworthy than God: their reason, their experience, their freedom, their intuition, their identity, their community, their morality, their tradition.
The center does not always confess, but it always operates.
And from that center flows an order:

- **Beliefs**: what we assume to be true
- **Values**: What we celebrate and stand for
- **Conduct**: What We Do Naturally

Here you have a clear explanation, guided and explicitly connected to Romans, keeping exactly that point: behavior does not correct, it reveals that the center has shifted.
That is why conduct is always the last link. It is not the beginning of the problem; it is its visible symptom. Romans makes this very clear from the beginning. Paul puts behavior "on trial," but not to reform it, but to show that something deeper is already out of place. Actions are not treated as the cause, but as the evidence.

In Romans, behavior appears as a witness, not as a physician. Paul exposes what people do to show what they are worshiping, what they trust, from where they interpret reality. When behavior becomes disordered, Paul responds not with immediate moral correction, but with a deeper diagnosis: the center has changed. The glory of God has been replaced by another reference, and life begins to organize itself around that new center.
So the problem is not simply that people do bad things, but that **they interpret life from the wrong source**. Conduct, then, is not the enemy to be defeated, but the sign that reveals that the truth has been suppressed, that the heart has exchanged references, that trust is no longer anchored in God. Correcting behavior without attending to this central shift would only produce external adjustment, not restoration.
Thus, Romans does not pursue behavior to discipline it, but exposes it to prove that the problem is internal, relational, and orientational. Behavior is brought to the stand not to be reformed, but to declare clearly that something deeper needs to be relocated: the center from which the person lives, reasons, and trusts.
This explains why it is so insufficient to start with "behave well!".
How can behavior heal what behavior itself is only exhibiting?
If the heart is disoriented, the behavior only becomes makeup.

The Collapse of Man Is Not Just Moral

The Bible (and Romans in particular) does not first diagnose humanity's problem as bad behavior, but as a change in the reference point that defines reality. And here we enter into an essential observation: when God is displaced as a reference, life is not neutral. It does not remain "the same but without religion". It is reoriented.
First it is noticeable in the behavior.
Then it is consolidated in values.
And finally it is justified in thought.
That is:

- what is wrong is done,
- then what "corresponds" is redefined,
- and then an explanation is constructed to defend it.

Isn't that how the human heart operates?
First choose, then evaluate, and then reason.
When this is understood, it is also understood why recovery cannot begin with effort. Because effort does not change the starting point.

Why the Restoration Begins with Revelation and Not Reformation

> *"The sum of Thy word is truth, and every one of Thy righteous ordinances is eternal." - Psalm 119:160*

If the problem were only behavior, God would give us instructions.
If it were only values, it would give us persuasion.
If it were just thought, it would give us information.

But God does something more radical: **he reveals himself**.

> *"He is the one who reveals the deep and the hidden." - Daniel 2:22*

> *For in the gospel the righteousness of God is revealed... - Romans 1:17*

God reveals what men cannot access

When we say that **God reveals what men cannot access**, we are affirming a real limit of the human being. It is not a matter of lack of intelligence, effort or sincerity. There are realities – who God is, where we come from, what is the meaning of life and of man – that human beings cannot reach by observation, introspection or autonomous reasoning. If God does not make himself known, man does not discover him.

That is why it is essential to understand that **God reveals the truth; Truth is not the product of human discovery**. Discovery implies that the truth is already available and that it only needs to be found. Revelation, on the other hand, affirms that the truth **was not within reach**, and that it is God who decides to make himself known. The initiative is not in the man who seeks, but in God who speaks. Knowledge of God does not begin with human curiosity, but with God making Himself known.

Moreover, the revelation does not happen all at once or in a chaotic way. It is initiated by God and is given **progressively**. God reveals Himself in stages, in words, deeds, and promises that accumulate and become clear over time. Each revelatory act does not contradict the previous one, but rather expands it, focuses it, and prepares it for something greater. The truth does not change, but the clarity increases.

This progressive process reaches its climax in Christ. Not because there was no true revelation before, but because in Christ revelation ceases to be fragmentary and becomes personal and full. In Him, God not only speaks the truth, but embodies **it**. Christ is not simply one more messenger in the chain of revelation; it is the point where God makes himself known in the most complete and definitive way possible.

> *God, having spoken long ago, on many occasions and in many ways... by the prophets, in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son... He is the radiance of His glory and the exact expression of His nature. Hebrews 1:1-3*

This must completely redefine how we understand truth. Truth is not something that man builds from below, but something that **God grants from above**. It is not achieved by accumulating human perspectives, but by receiving what God has chosen to show. That is why faith is not an irrational leap, but a reasonable response to a revelation that could not have occurred otherwise. Revelation breeds responsibility, not neutrality (Romans 1:18-21).

Because the root of the problem is not just what we do. It's what we treat as real.

What is the Gospel, then?

It is not a new set of rules. It's not a better motivation. It is not an additional help for us to finally "can".
Nor is it something that man has discovered or defined.

> *"The gospel preached by me is not according to man... but by revelation of Jesus Christ." Galatians 1:11-12*

It is God acting from outside the human system to restore what man cannot restore from within.

> *"God sent His Son into the world..." - John 3:16*

And it is precisely with this center that Paul will begin his letter to the Romans.

> *"Set apart for the gospel of God... which He had promised before." - Romans 1:1–2*

With this clear, Romans can begin.

What to think about:

- From where do I usually define what is "real": from what God declares or from what I experience?
- What authority does my experience have in the face of revelation?
- Why does it come so naturally to me to start with myself, even when I claim to believe in God?
- How does my reading of the Bible change if I see it as revelation and not as counsel?
- What happens when I treat my feelings as arbiters of truth?
- Can there be true stability if the benchmark is constantly changing?
- What do I lose—and what do I gain—if I accept that reality is true before I understand it?

MOVEMENT 1 - GOD AS REFERENCE

(Romans 1:1–17)
If one approaches Romans in a hurry, it is easy to think that Paul is simply fulfilling an introduction.
A formal greeting before getting into the important stuff. But a closer reading reveals something quite different.
Paul is not opening a letter. It is **establishing a starting point**.
And that starting point is not accidental.
We usually start with ourselves. With how we feel, with what worries us, with what we don't understand, with what we would like to correct. Our reading of reality almost always begins from experience.

Paul does not do that.
Paul begins with God.
From the first line he makes it clear that the gospel is not a response built from the human crisis, but a declaration that comes from God himself.

> *"... of Christ Jesus... for the gospel of God" - Romans 1:1*

This establishes something fundamental: before man interprets his situation, **God has already spoken**. The gospel does not arise as a progressive solution to our problems, but as an affirmation of reality as God defines it.
That is why Paul presents himself as a servant, called and set apart. He does not introduce himself as a thinker, or as a reformer, or as someone who came to certain conclusions. He presents himself as someone **located within a previous authority**. Their identity is not the origin of the message; it is evidence that the message precedes it.
This is not a minor detail. It corrects the reader from the beginning.
Because if the messenger is not the origin, then the reader cannot position himself as a judge either. The message does not depend on Paul's charism, nor on his history, nor on his rhetorical capacity. It is not sustained by its experience. It comes from God.

> *"The gospel ... I received it through a revelation of Jesus Christ." — Galatians 1:11–12*

Here is exposed one of our most frequent temptations: to treat the truth as something we validate according to who says it or how it makes us feel. Romans leaves no room for that. From the outset it is clear that this is not a message *about* God; it is a message **from God**.
And the center of that message is not a method or a system.
He is a person.

> *"It is the message about His Son..." — Romans 1:3*

Paul places the Son at the center not as a devotional figure, but as the point where reality becomes public. The gospel does not describe how human beings encounter God; it announces that **God has come to act and reveal himself**.
This completely changes the tone of Christianity.
Because many live as if the gospel were a path we take to achieve stability.

I also experienced it that way.

If I'm honest, I tried to figure it out exactly that way.
I served as a missionary for thirteen years.
He had sincerity.
I wanted to help people.
But more than that, I wanted to do something for God.

I was giving my best for Jesus.

He made compromises.
He promised to do better.

And, to be honest, he was quite disciplined.
Sometimes I even felt a certain pride in having achieved some spiritual goals.

Other days, on the other hand, I felt completely guilty and condemned for not meeting my own expectations.

He lived in cycles.
Effort.
Achievement.
Pride.
Failure.
Guilt.
Repeat.

There was a moment when I was already deeply fatigued—spiritually and ministerially exhausted—when someone asked me a simple question:

"John, if you died today and God asked you:
'Why should I let you in?'
What would you answer?"

I thought for just a second.

And I answered without hesitation:
"Because I gave you my life."

He looked at me and replied:

"How interesting.
I thought He gave His life for you."

That phrase disarmed me.
Because for the first time I understood that my answer revealed what I was really trusting.

Without realizing it, I had made the gospel my story of effort.

He did not deny it.
In a way he preached it.

But he had reduced it to a necessary message...
not enough.

Without realizing it, he had stripped the gospel of its power,
because I had transformed it into something that ultimately depended on me.

And that's exactly what Paul is correcting.

Paul does not present the gospel as a process that we complete.
He presents it as an intervention that has already occurred... If God has already spoken in His Son, then the question is not how to secure that message, but **how to live in light of something that has already been declared**. There is nothing left to negotiate, or to complete, or to demonstrate.
Here we begin to perceive something decisive: Christianity does not stand on our ability to sustain it.

This explains why Paul writes to believers.

At first glance it might seem unnecessary to re-explain the gospel to those who already believe. But Pablo knows something that we easily forget: knowing information is not the same as living from an established reality.

> *"It is not troublesome for me to write the same things to you, and it is safe for you." -Philippians 3:1*

A believer can affirm correct doctrines and still live insecurely. You can say "I'm saved" and inadvertently interpret every fall as a threat. You can talk about grace and still organize your life as if God is constantly evaluating.
That is why Romans does not add something new to what we already know. Rather**, it removes** the much that is not, to establish clearly what is the only thing that is. Paul does not write to add religion, but to recover the foundation from which life can be sustained.
In this context, one of the best-known – and most easily reduced – affirmations of the letter appears: **the gospel is the power of God unto salvation**.
Paul is not saying that the gospel has the power to inspire. He's saying that the gospel **does** something. It doesn't just teach, it doesn't just inform, it doesn't just motivate. Take action. If the problem were only ignorance, an explanation would suffice. But if the problem is that reality has been displaced, then power is needed: power to restore, power to establish, power to relocate the human being in a new condition.
Here the central theme of the book begins to take shape: if the gospel is the power of God, then salvation does not rest in what man manages to maintain, but in what God accomplishes.
That is why Paul affirms that in the gospel the righteousness of God is revealed. It doesn't say, "Here's how to be fair." He says, "Here the righteousness of God is revealed." Justice does not begin with our behavior, but with what God declares true and right before Himself.
And this revelation produces rest.
Because if justice depended on producing it, life would be a constant tension: was it enough, was I consistent, did I go back too far? But if righteousness comes from God, then there is a basis that does not change with our fluctuations.
Romans begins here, with God, deliberately.
Paul has not yet diagnosed sin, and that is intentional. Because if the reader begins with sin, he will interpret everything from the point of view of the human being. But if it begins with God, sin will be seen in its right place: real and devastating, but not ultimate. Serious, but not sovereign. Reality begins with God.

And once that is firmly established, Romans can accurately describe what happens when God is displaced.
That will be the next move.

What to think about:

- Why does Paul begin with God and not with the human problem?
- What does the fact that I would prefer to begin my struggles reveal about me?
- What does it mean that the gospel is power and not just information? If the gospel is the power of God,
- Why do I usually treat it as something I should "apply"?
- What changes if justice is not produced, but revealed?
- What kind of security is possible if the verdict precedes my experience?
- If Paul writes this to believers, what does that say about how easy it is to lose clarity?

MOVEMENT 2 - GOD IS DISPLACED

(Romans 1:18–32)
Paul does not start from human suffering to explain the gospel. It starts from a deeper truth: the human being is not simply confused or hurt. It is **misaligned with God's truth**.
And right from the start, he clarifies something essential that is often overlooked:
God has not been eliminated from the world. He has been displaced.
It is not an absence.
It is about substitution.
The problem is not that mankind has emptied His altar.
It's that he has filled it with something else.

The Truth Is Not Lost by Accident

Paul says that the truth has been **suppressed**.
Not ignored. Not simply misunderstood.
Deleted.
This means that the underlying problem is not a lack of information, but an **active resistance to what is known**.
What can be known about God is not hidden. It's clear. It's accessible. It is imprinted in what is created.
And yet, **another narrative** has been chosen.
This choice is not neutral. It is not passive.
Paul calls it with a strong word: *change*.

> *and **they exchanged** the glory of the incorruptible God for an image in the form of corruptible man, birds, four-legged animals, and creeping things. - Romans 1:23*

Revelation Breeds Responsibility, Not Neutrality (Romans 1:18–21)

Revelation never leaves the human being in a neutral point. It has strong consequences. In Romans 1, Paul does not describe people who lack information, but people who **have received enough light** to respond. God has made Himself known in such a way that His truth is perceptible, recognizable, and meaningful. So the problem Paul points out is not ignorance, but the **response** to what has been revealed.
When the truth is revealed, responsibility inevitably ensues. Not because man now has more rules, but because he **can no longer claim absence of reference**. Revelation establishes an external, universal criterion before which the human being must situate himself. That is why Paul can claim that men "*knew God*," but they did not respond according to that knowledge. The revelation was not insufficient; The response was inadequate.

> *For since the creation of the world, His invisible attributes, His eternal power and divinity, have been seen plainly, being understood by the created, so that they are without excuse.- Romans 1:20*

This brings us to the central point: **the root of the problem is not just what we do**. Behavior is important, but it is not the origin of the collapse. The break happens earlier, at a deeper level. The fundamental problem is **what we treat as real**, what we assume as the ultimate reference for interpreting life, value and meaning. When God ceases to be that reference, reality itself begins to be reinterpreted.

> *... they did not honor him as God or give thanks to him, but they became vain in their reasoning, and their foolish hearts were darkened. Romans 1:21*

That is why Paul does not begin by correcting specific actions. He first exposes an internal displacement: the truth is known, but not honest; God is revealed, but not recognized as the center. From there, the behavior simply **expresses** what has already happened at the baseline level. Revelation, then, does not produce neutrality, but a clear division: either it is answered with recognition and gratitude, or it is answered with suppression and replacement.

In this framework, sin is not merely doing the wrong thing, but living from a redefined reality, where creation occupies the place that only God can occupy. Responsibility arises precisely because revelation has been given. God does not leave man in the dark, and so the answer is never neutral. Where there is revelation, there is an answer (right or wrong). And where there is an answer, the behavior ends up revealing what has been treated as truly real.

That is why Paul does not move forward in a hurry, nor does he adopt a moralistic tone, nor does he try to shock the reader with a list of carefully selected sins. He does not write to scandalize, but to **explain**. Behavior appears in his argument not as the starting point, but as the visible evidence of something that has already happened more profoundly.

What Paul is doing is helping us understand **why the world is the way it is**. The disorder we see does not arise from isolated errors or simple flaws of character, but from a deeper displacement: the center from which human beings interpret reality has changed. And as long as that center is not restored, no external adjustment will suffice.

Therefore, human beings cannot correct themselves simply by trying to live better. The problem is not a lack of effort, but a wrong reference. Behavior cannot heal what can only be restored when reality is once again interpreted from God as a criterion.

Nor does Paul seek to improve the world with a more God-centered behavior. Paul is not wanting to rehabilitate the world. By conduct, Paul demonstrates man's true spiritual condition and need of an external rescue.

God Acts in the Face of Rejection

When revelation is ignored, suppressed, or displaced, human beings are not simply "alone with themselves," as if that were a safe or autonomous space. Romans makes it clear that as long as

man is still alive, God does not allow man to lock himself indefinitely into his own schemes without consequences.
This is crucial: **God acts in the face of the rejection of revelation**. He does not do it to destroy arbitrarily, nor by capricious abandonment, but to show the reality of the chosen path. When man insists on redefining reality from another reference, God responds by allowing that reference to fully govern. The result is not true freedom, but exposure. Man is confronted with what his own criteria produce when they occupy the place that only God can occupy.
Therefore, God's action does not consist in imposing immediate correction, but in not intervening to sustain an illusion. God's response is to simply remove the brakes, not because He approves of the deviation, but because He does not allow man to live deceived about the consequences of rejecting the truth. Abandonment is not the absence of divine action, but a severe form of revelatory action. That is, God continues to reveal Himself even in rejection.
So God has not only revealed man through creation. God has also revealed His righteousness through the gospel. And now finally, God answers man and continues to reveal his wrath to man. In this sense, God does not leave man at the mercy of his own devices as if these were sufficient. By allowing the heart to take its course, God reveals something essential: what man builds when God ceases to be his reference. Thus, even the judgment has a revealing character. It makes visible that the problem is not external, but internal; it is not circumstantial, but referential.
In this way, even in the rejection of revelation, God remains the one who governs history. Man can change his point of reference, but he cannot escape the reality that God has established. The rejected revelation does not disappear; it becomes the criterion by which life itself exposes its falsehood.
What kind of life is built when man's utility supersedes God's truth?
A practical life, perhaps sincere... but profoundly unstable.
With this established, we will see how a downward spiral is unleashed between God and man on three successive levels: conduct, values and mind.

The First Collapse: Behavior

> *Wherefore God gave them over to impurity in the lust of their hearts... Romans 1:24*

Paul begins by describing what is most visible: **human behavior**. Not because it is the most important thing, but because it is the most obvious. It is the first thing that everyone can observe and, for this reason, it is often confused with the root of the problem.
Behavior becomes disordered because it no longer flows from a reality established by God. He begins to respond to impulses, desires, and pressures that are disconnected from the truth. Not because human beings have stopped knowing what is right, but because what is right has lost authority. The reference still exists, but it no longer governs.
Here an uncomfortable, but necessary question arises:
How many times do we treat behavior as the main problem, when in reality it is only the most obvious symptom?
When behavior becomes the center of the diagnosis, the solution seems obvious: change behavior. Then the rules appear, the external pressure, the constant surveillance, the comparison with others. All the effort is concentrated on producing a visible result, without paying attention to the cause that generates it.

But Paul doesn't do that. It doesn't try to correct what people do first. Describe behavior to show that something deeper has already moved. Behavior is not the origin of the collapse; it is the evidence that the center from which life is interpreted and organized is no longer God. The main problem is much worse than behavior. It is a matter of man being spiritually dead.

> *"The body is dead because of sin..." – Romans 8:10*

What happens as a result is ungodly behavior.

The Second Collapse: Values

> *For this reason God gave them over to degrading passions; - Romans 1:26*

When truth is suppressed, God does not leave man in a neutral state. It acts by handing it over to a mind that reorganizes values.
What used to cause shame is beginning to be justified.
What used to be uncomfortable is beginning to normalize.
What was previously resisted is beginning to be celebrated.
This is not an accidental process. It is a moral reorganization. Values do not change because human beings have reflected better, nor because they have reached deeper moral conclusions. They change because **God acts judicially** in the face of the rejection of the truth. As Paul describes in Romans, when truth is suppressed, **God gives** man over to a way of thinking that must now sustain what he is already doing.
The result is inevitable: no one lives comfortably under a permanent contradiction. But it is not the man who, autonomously, readjusts his values to feel better about himself. It is God who **removes the brakes**, and in doing so, allows the mind to reorganize reality to give coherence to the chosen disorder.
Thus, values end up aligning with behavior, not as an initial cause, but as **an expression of judgment**. The redefinition of the good does not correct life; justifies it. However, God continues to faithfully reveal, His righteousness in the gospel, His power and deity in creation, and His wrath against the injustice of men.
Doesn't this explain why many moral discussions seem impossible?
It is not simply a matter of ethical disagreements or a lack of convincing arguments. These are **different points of reference.** When God ceases to define what is good, something else must take that place. And once that new criterion is established, the dialogue no longer revolves around the truth, but around **what reality is accepted as valid**.

The Deepest Collapse: The Way of Reasoning

> *"... God gave them over to a depraved mind..." - Romans 1:28*

Paul saves the most serious for last: the collapse of reasoning.
This point is key to understanding Romans—and to understanding ourselves.
The problem is not that human beings have stopped reasoning.

The problem is that reason no longer points to the truth.
Thought does not become irrational. It becomes functional. He does not stop reasoning; he begins to reason **in the service of something**. It serves what has already been elected, defends what is already valued and justifies what is already practiced. The mind does not lose capacity; **he changes allegiance**.
At this point, the fundamental question is no longer, "What is true?" The question has shifted. Now it is: "how can I sustain what I have already decided?" Reason no longer operates as an instrument to discover the truth, but as a tool to protect a previous choice.
This is where the process becomes recognizable—and deeply human:
Don't we see this dynamic even in ourselves?
How many times do we look for arguments **after** we have made a decision?
How many times do we reinterpret reality, not to understand it better, but to **avoid having to let go of what we want to keep**? Paul describes precisely this state: a mind that **has not lost its ability to think**, but has lost its **direction**. It is not an empty mind, but a mind guided by a wrong reference. The logic continues to work; what has changed is **who it serves**.

> *"The mind set on the flesh is the enemy of God..." - Romans 8:7*

Therefore, when God is displaced, thought is neither neutral nor free. **He is captive**. Not captive by lack of intelligence, but by a prior loyalty that now governs what is considered reasonable, acceptable, and true. The mind is not turned off; is **busy**.

> *"... satisfying the desires of the flesh and the mind... sons of wrath..." - Ephesians 2:3*

A Devastating and Necessary Diagnosis.

This triple collapse (behavior, values, thinking) has an inevitable implication: **recovery from within is impossible**. If the behavior is disordered, discipline is not enough. If the values are inverted, exhortation is not enough. If thinking is disoriented, education is not enough.
The problem is not superficial. Nor is it merely structural or cultural. **It is spiritual**. Paul is not describing a system that malfunctions and needs adjustment, but a condition that affects the very core of the human being. That is why no external reorganization can solve it. The problem is not only in what man does, or even only in how he thinks, but in **where he lives and reasons**.
And here Paul closes the door to all false hope of self-salvation. If the problem were one of information, more knowledge would suffice. If it were behavioral, more discipline would suffice. If it were a social structure, reforms would suffice. But Paul has shown something deeper: **even thought is affected**. The mind has not disappeared, but it can no longer function as the final arbiter of truth because it is oriented from a wrong reference. That is why the question changes level and becomes inescapable:
What recourse is left when even thought can no longer be trusted as the judge of truth?
The answer is decisive: only one. Revelation that comes **from outside the system**. If the human being is locked within a misinterpreted reality, he cannot correct himself from within. He needs truth to be given to him, not discovered; revealed, not constructed.
There is an understanding of why Romans does not move directly to practical instructions. Paul does not begin by saying *"do this"* or *"stop doing that."* Move on to intervention first. To an action

of God that breaks into a closed system and reestablishes the correct reference. Only after that intervention occurs can behavior and thinking be truly transformed.
In Romans, the hope is not that man thinks better for himself, but that God acts. Not in self-improvement, but in revelation and new life. That is why the gospel is not moral counsel, but **the power of God**.
Paul does not describe this to shame

Paul does not expose human collapse to humiliate the reader, but to **legitimize what God is about to do**.
That's why it's important to notice their tone. He does not write from contempt. He does not speak from a supposed moral superiority.
Speak clearly.
He describes the human condition not to crush the reader, but to make something absolutely clear: **no one can fix this from the inside**. If the problem reached the center—the mind, the reference, the spiritual life—then no internal correction will suffice.
When this reality is not accepted, grace will always seem excessive. Security will seem dangerous. The justification will seem irresponsible. But when the diagnosis is understood, the solution ceases to seem extreme... and it begins to seem **necessary**.

The Transition Point

So far, Romans has done two things:

1. He has established God as the reference point of reality.
2. It has shown what happens when that reference point is displaced.

He has not yet presented the solution. And that's deliberate, too.
Paul knows that if the reader does not see the problem clearly, **he will inevitably reduce God's answer** to something manageable, partial, or cooperative. Grace becomes complement. Divine intervention is diluted in human effort. The gospel becomes help, not rescue.
Romans will not allow that.
That is why Paul does not rush. He insists on the diagnosis until it is clear that the problem does not admit internal solutions or progressive adjustments. Only then can you introduce the decisive turning point of the argument. In the next movement, Paul will not present what man should do, but **what God does when man cannot**.
That is the center of the message.
Therein lies the heart of the gospel.

What to think about:

- What is it like to displace God without explicitly denying Him?
- What things tend to occupy the place of reference in everyday life?
- What does the difference look like between ignoring God and replacing Him?
- Why does collapse begin with behavior, but not end there?
- What values do you see adjusting to justify behaviors already chosen?
- In what ways can thought serve desire rather than truth?
- What real hope is left if even the mind loses its bearings?

MOVE 3 - NO HUMAN ADVANTAGE

(Romans 2:1-3:20)

After describing the collapse that occurs when God is displaced, Paul does something that may be uncomfortable for many readers: he **does not allow anyone to be placed outside the diagnosis**. He does not allow the reader to remain as a moral spectator, analyzing the world from a supposed height. Their strategy is straightforward: if the problem is referential – if the center has moved – then the most dangerous self-deception is not only "doing the wrong thing", but **thinking that I am not included in the diagnosis**.

So far, it might seem easy to nod. It's easy to say, "yes, that's the way the world is." Easy to think of others. It is easy to locate the problem in "outsiders".

But Paul does not allow it.

In Romans 2, Paul begins to disarm one of the most common human defenses: **comparative advantage**. That inner feeling of being better than others, not necessarily because one is a saint, but because one has something: more information, more norms, more discipline, more culture, more tradition, more "conscience", more religious language, more sense of justice. It's a subtle illusion: *"I'm not like them."* And that illusion works as a refuge. As long as it exists, humans can keep the diagnosis at a distance.

That is why Paul turns his attention to the one who judges. And he makes it personal, he says, "you who judge." Not to tell him "you're worse," but to show him something deeper: that judgment can become a way to protect himself. The judge is reassured because he identifies the evil in others, but he overlooks that this same reaction reveals an internal problem: **he places himself as a reference**. Instead of submitting to God's criteria, he clings to his own criteria, even if that criterion is moral or religious. That is, the conduct of others is condemned, but one's own heart remains intact.

Paul then elevates the conversation: the issue is not just what man does, but how he responds to God's truth and patience. God's goodness does not exist to feed a sense of superiority, but to lead man to reconsider. But the heart can twist even that: it can read patience as approval, and it can interpret time as permission. Thus, the apparent "advantage" becomes another instrument for their own deception.

In Romans 2:12–29, Paul closes all doors. He shows that neither law, nor identity, nor symbols, nor external privileges produce justice. On the contrary: they can become a stage where man *learns to hide better*. The law, instead of being a step towards God, becomes a mirror that man avoids, or a rule by which he measures others so as not to look at himself. Paul insists: it is not enough to have the norm; the problem is that the human being, even with a norm, is still capable of displacing God as a reference.

In Romans 3:1–8, Paul recognizes that there are real privileges (especially for the Jew), but he does not allow those privileges to become a basis of trust. And in Romans 3:9–20, Paul comes to

the inevitable closure: **There is no human advantage that can reverse the diagnosis**. The conclusion is not simply "everyone sins," but something more radical: no one has an internal reference reliable enough to justify himself before God. The law cannot save; it can only **make** the problem visible. Man does not need an external correction as a final solution; It needs the center to be restored, because the collapse began there.

Judgment Is Not Avoided by Acknowledging the Problem

Paul begins by dismantling a silent but deeply held assumption: that **recognizing evil in others is tantamount to being safe from it**. That clearly seeing the disorder of others, denouncing it or even condemning it, automatically places us in a different, safer, more correct position.
Judging the messiness of others can produce a momentary sense of moral clarity. It produces distance. It produces relief. It gives the impression of being on the right side of the line. As long as the problem has an external face, the diagnosis seems controllable. Evil is "over there," and I am "here."
But Paul introduces a question that disarms that comfort at its root:
What criteria do you judge by?
Because the very act of judging reveals something disturbing: **the one who judges recognizes the standard**. It recognizes that there is a measure, a norm, a distinction between what corresponds and what does not. And that same rule is not suspended by the fact that it is indicated in others. On the contrary, the recognition of the criterion implies responsibility towards it.
Here Paul is not denouncing judgment as an act, nor forbidding all moral evaluation. Its focus is different. He is exposing **the false security that is supported by the judgment**. The idea that identifying the problem is equivalent to not participating in it. That naming evil is the same as being free from evil. That moral lucidity replaces the need for personal surrender.
The problem is not that the judge correctly sees the disorder. The problem is that **he uses that vision as a refuge**. Judgment then becomes a strategy of self-protection: not to align oneself with the truth, but to better place oneself within it. The truth ceases to be a criterion that judges me, and becomes a tool that I use.
That is why judgment, far from avoiding God's judgment, can actually **expose a misplaced trust**. Not a denial of truth, but an appropriation of it to sustain a sense of advantage. The heart does not submit to the criterion; he administers it.
And here Paul's question reaches us strongly:
Isn't this one of our favorite shelters?
Not to deny the truth, but to use it to position ourselves better than others.
Not to reject the diagnosis, but to apply it selectively.
Not to escape from the standard, but to momentarily place ourselves as interpreters of the standard.

Thus, judgment does not become a path to humility, but a refined mode of escape. And Paul does not allow that evasion to remain intact. Because as long as the trial functions as a refuge, the heart remains beyond the reach of the real diagnosis.

Morality Gives No Advantage

Paul then addresses himself — without naming names, but with complete clarity — to a type of reader who usually feels relatively secure: the one who lives with a certain visible righteousness. Responsible people. Disciplined people. People who value the good. People who, compared to the clutter described above, seem to be "on the right side."

And here something important happens: Paul **does not deny the social value of morality**. He does not ridicule it. He does not despise it. He does not claim that he is useless on the human plane. Morality can order the external life. It can benefit others. Can reduce damage. It can produce social stability. It can even preserve a community.

But Paul does something more appropriate: **he puts it in its right place**.

Because Romanos is not building a thesis on social coexistence. He's dealing with the judgment seat of God. And in this scenario, visible morality does not function as a safe-conduct. It can improve behavior, but it cannot produce **righteousness before God**.

The reason is profound: the problem is not only *what is done*, but **from where it is done** and, even more, **who defines the measure**. The human being can conform externally to certain norms and yet continue to operate from the wrong center. He can do "the right thing" while the benchmark remains himself: his reputation, his superiority, his inner tranquility, his control, his identity.

That is why Paul does not stop at conduct. What he examines is the ground on which behavior rests. A moral life can become a form of self-affirmation. It can become a way of saying: "I am fine". And when that happens, morality ceases to be an expression of order and becomes a source of security.

Here comes the inevitable question:

What happens when morality becomes the basis of security?

Something very human happens: morality is transformed into comparison. And comparison always needs someone worse. It always demands an "other" that functions as a contrast to sustain the feeling of advantage. Security stops resting on truth, and begins to rest in a distance: "I am not like them."

And that is the point where Pablo presses. Because that ground seems solid, but it is fragile. If my confidence depends on being better than someone else, then my peace depends on someone more disorderly existing. If my righteousness depends on comparison, then I'm not really seeking righteousness: I'm seeking **position**.

That is why Paul does not allow that ground. Not because morality is bad, but because **it cannot bear the weight of security before God**. Morality can order on the outside, but it cannot establish the right center on the inside. And as long as the center continues to be displaced, the advantage is illusion. The only thing that changes is that the illusion becomes respectable.

Religion Doesn't Solve the Problem Either

After showing that neither obvious disorder nor visible morality confers advantage, Paul takes a more delicate step. Now it is addressed to those who possess something that seems decisive: **revelation**. People who are not only trying to live well, but who **know God's will**. People with Scripture, with theological language, with clear spiritual categories.

Here the argument becomes sensitive, because Paul is not speaking of ignorance, but of **privilege**. To have received the law, to know what God approves of and disapproves, to have access to His word... All of this seems to put someone in a different position. Closer. Safer. More informed.

And Paul does not deny that privilege. It does not say that revelation does not matter. It does not minimize the value of knowing the truth. On the contrary, it recognizes that the law is good, that it reveals what is just, that it clearly shows what corresponds. Again, the problem is not in the revelation.

The problem is in **what we do with it**.

That is why Paul introduces a crucial distinction that makes the religious reader uncomfortable:

Knowing the truth is not the same as being aligned with it.

The law may show the standard with absolute accuracy, but **it does not produce the ability to live it**. It can illuminate what is right, but it cannot change the center from which a person lives. It may inform the mind, but it does not transform the heart. Revelation clarifies, but does not reorder on its own.

This is where Paul's argument gets personal. Because the religious temptation is not usually to deny the truth, but **to turn it into identity**. The person is no longer dependent on God; it depends on what you know about God. Revelation ceases to be something that confronts and sustains me, and becomes something that defines and protects.

So a difficult but necessary question arises:

What happens when revelation becomes identity, rather than dependence?

It happens that the relationship with God is displaced. Trust is no longer in Him, but in the access I have to His word, in my right understanding, in my religious belonging, in my familiarity with the sacred. The truth ceases to be a voice that judges and corrects me, and becomes a credential that I present.

That is why Paul affirms something that may be uncomfortable: **religion, when used as a credential, does not protect against judgment**. In fact, it can **intensify accountability**. Not because the law is bad, but because it has received more light. This implies accountability more clearly. Disclosure does not lower the standard; it makes it more visible.
Paul's point is not to attack the faith or discredit Scripture. It is something deeper: to show that **clarity is not a substitute for justice**. Knowing what is right is not the same as living from the right center. And as long as revelation functions as a substitute for dependence—rather than leading to it—the problem remains intact.
Thus, Pablo closes another possible way out. It is not enough to be moral. It is not enough to be religious. It is not enough to know the truth. If revelation does not lead to a **relocation of the center**, then even spiritual privilege can become a refined form of self-deception.
If you've lived for years thinking that your biblical knowledge gave you security, this point can feel disorienting.
It is normal for something internal to resist.
Discovering that knowing the truth does not equate to being aligned with it can produce spiritual vertigo.

You're not crazy if this makes you uncomfortable.

But discomfort does not mean that the argument is false. It means that the shelter was deeper than you thought.

The Underlying Problem: Listening Without Responding

At this point, Paul is not attacking irreligious people, nor religious people, nor moral people.
He is dismantling an idea common to all: that **closeness to the truth equals security**.
But truth does not protect by proximity.
It protects only when **God acts**.
Paul insists: it is not the hearers of the law who are righteous in the sight of God, but those who keep it.
And here the attentive reader must stop.
Because this statement is not designed to reassure. It is designed to close an exit.
Who can really claim to have fulfilled it?
Who can sustain themselves there without recomparing, relativizing or redefining?
Paul does not answer yet.
Just let the weight of the question remain.

When All Comparison Collapses

As the argument progresses, one thing becomes apparent: **every possible advantage has been neutralized**.

- Immorality does not protect.
- Morality does not protect.
- Religion does not protect.
- Knowledge does not protect.

Everything we normally use to differentiate ourselves has been put on the same level.
And so Paul does something definitive: **he unites everyone under one condition**.
Not as rhetorical exaggeration.
Not as religious pessimism.
But as a logical conclusion.
They are all under sin.
It is not just a matter of individual acts here. It is a common condition that crosses all humanity.

The problem was clearly expressed

There comes a time when the question is no longer whether something is wrong, but whether it can be corrected.
Most people live with the silent assumption that what has gone astray can eventually be fixed.
With enough time, enough effort, enough learning, enough sincerity — the balance will return.
The future will compensate for the past.
But some realities do not respond to the effort.
They do not bow to sincerity.
They are not intentionally softened.
They just remain.
The problem is not only that mistakes have been made. The problem is that errors accumulate in a way that cannot be reversed with future behaviors.
Time advances, but it does not erase what has already happened. What has been done is not undone because now we wish it had not happened.
And along with this unalterable record comes another difficulty: it's not just that something has gone wrong, but that we don't possess the necessary condition to be in full alignment with the right thing.
It is not simply a failure of actions, but a lack of nuance.
Not a momentary lapse, but an absence of the necessary position.

This creates a double barrier:

- The past cannot be edited.
- The present does not carry the necessary credential to enter without impediments.

At first glance, this seems solvable.
Instinctively we seek to improve, educate, discipline, reform.
But improvement addresses future behavior — it doesn't revise history.
Discipline can refine behavior — it does not alter legitimation.
Sincerity can change intent — it doesn't change nuance.
The tools available are real tools, but they are not tools for this problem.
And this is the point that most people never allow themselves to reach:
the realization that the problem is not intensity, knowledge, or determination.
The problem is that the problem itself cannot be repaired from within.
There is no angle left to discuss.
No clause that overlooks.
There is no compensatory effort strong enough to rebalance the scale.
When all internal strategies are exhausted, the mind becomes silent.
Not out of desperation, but out of the recognition that there is nothing left to present.

> *... the Law... he says it to those who are under the law, so that every mouth may be silenced and everyone may be held accountable to God; Romans 3:19*

The Standard That Doesn't Move

The urge to fix things is strong. Almost automatic.
When something is wrong, we think that with enough correction it will return to its place and that insisting makes up for it. But compensating is not the same as correcting. A person may become more disciplined, more informed, more intentional, but that doesn't erase what already exists. Knowing more does not eliminate what has been established.
Having good intentions does not take away the consequences.

The problem is not only one of behavior; it is also structure. The past is still present in a way that effort is not always enough. And the standard doesn't go down to match our progress. What is needed is still what is needed.

This is where the illusion begins to become clear. Not because a person doesn't want to, but because the will is not the missing ingredient.

The realization arises in silence:

There is no forward movement that comes backwards.

There is no internal adjustment that produces the qualification itself.

There is no argument that alters the measure applied.

At that moment the question changes.

It's no longer " *How do I fix this?"*

It becomes, *"Can it be fixed from where I am?"*

And the honest answer, when all the optimism has been examined, is disarming in its simplicity:

There is nothing left within reach to solve it.

Not because effort is useless.

Not because the intention is insincere.

But because the nature of the problem is outside the tools available.

When each internal lever has been tried and found to have no relation to the outcome, the mind does not panic: it calms down.

Not in desperation, but in the recognition that self-resolution has reached its limit.

And yet, the thought remains:

There must be something I can do.

This reaction is not pride. It's customary. In most areas of life, problems give way to effort. When something breaks, we repair it. When we fall behind, we work harder. When we lack knowledge, we study. Experience has taught us that persistence changes results. It's natural to assume that this situation follows the same pattern.

Thus begins the search.

We think maybe more commitment will help.

Maybe understand better.

Maybe more discipline or more perseverance.

All of that seems reasonable, and many times it works to some extent.

The problem is that all these answers are forward-looking. They can improve what we do, but they don't change what already is. They can adjust the behavior, but they do not create the qualification.
They improve performance, but they do not transform position.
Over time, the question changes.
It's no longer "what else can I try?" but "is there anything that really solves this at the root?"
And little by little it becomes evident:
Tools that are useful for other things are not useful here.
Not because they are weak, but because they were not made for this kind of problem.
Understanding does not come with force.
It arrives by discarding.
One approach after another is tried, and none touch on the real problem.
Desire is sincere, but sincerity does not change facts, and effort does not rewrite what is already established.
What remains is not defeat.
It's clarity.
At that point we understand that the issue is not how much we try, but whether what we try actually addresses the problem.
And then it becomes necessary to look at an external reference — not an imposed authority, but a standard that simply exists.
Each area has its measure. He does not adapt to the effort or leave due to insistence.
It remains what it is. When this is understood, the internal discussion ends.
Not because of pressure, but because the reality is clear.
What remains is not confusion or despair.
It is recognition

> *".... by the works of the law no human being will be justified before Him; for through the law comes the knowledge of sin." - Romans 3:20*

What opposes us is not only what we did, but what we can no longer undo.
The past is not erased with more effort.
Actions accumulate, and neither discipline nor sincerity eliminate them. These accumulations remain in the form of debt. The worst thing is that it is not a debt to God, not to man.

And there is another reality:
We don't carry within us what is necessary for a complete alignment. We do not have the righteousness necessary to be acceptable to God.
It's not just that we sometimes fail; we don't have the qualification itself.
What is required is not something partial, but complete, and that standard does not come down with our progress.

These two things are found:
There is still an outstanding debt to God.
We don't have the righteousness necessary to be acceptable to God.
This transfers the problem of personal alignment to objective reality. The issue is no longer limited to our own conscience or social consequences. It refers to the One who defines what is right. What remains is not simply an internal memory or a private charge; it is a gap measured in relation to God himself.
Time does not eliminate this. The upgrade doesn't cancel it out. Greater discipline can influence future decisions, but it does not undo what has already been established.
Along with this there is another fact. Alignment with God is not achieved by partial progress or gradual refinement. The required condition is not approximate compatibility, but complete correspondence with His standard. That requirement does not change with effort, and it is not softened by the sincere intention. It remains fixed because it is based on who He is, not on how we act.
These two realities stand together.
What has been established is against God and cannot be undone by future actions.
What is required to be fully aligned with God is not something we naturally possess.
From here, the questions are no longer abstract.
How much effort has been invested in correcting what is opposed to God?
How much reform, learning, or discipline has been implemented?
And what has been the result?
Did the effort eliminate what existed?
Did you produce the required qualification?
Did it meet the measure — or did the measure remain unchanged, continuing to require what had not yet been achieved?
For most, the answer is coherent rather than dramatic. The effort was real. The intention was genuine. However, the standard (the law) did not change. He asked for what he always asked for, and every attempt, no matter how sincere, came close—but never came.
When all of this is considered together, the situation becomes difficult to discuss. The issue is not just that a mistake occurred, but that it was against God and cannot be reversed by future actions. The past remains established in a way that effort does not intercept. At the same time, the necessary condition to be fully aligned with God is not something we naturally carry. The requirement is not bent toward intention, nor is it lowered to achieve improvement. It remains what it is.
This is not a conclusion that is reached by pessimism or exaggeration. It is achieved through comparison. Each internal strategy has been reviewed. All available tools have been tested. Effort has been applied, sincerity has been present, discipline has been exercised — and yet the distance between what exists and what is demanded has not been reduced.

The Purpose of the Law Is Clear

At this point, Paul finally clarifies the role of the law with
a precision that many overlook.
The law was not given to justify.
It was given to **make visible**.
To define the standard.
To expose the distance.
To close your mouth.
This image is powerful: every mouth shut.
Not because there is nothing to say, but because **there is no longer possible defense**.

At this point the discussion remains silent, not because there is nothing to say, but because there is nothing left to discuss. The matter has been analyzed from all available angles. The tools that shape the future do not rewrite the past. The desire to solve does not generate the required qualification. The comparison remains.
It is very clear.
It is recognition.
And recognition leads to a simple, unvarnished conclusion: "We

can't solve this."

We are finished.

If you feel a mixture of silence and resistance when reading this, that is human.

No one enjoys getting to the point where they can no longer present anything.

The mind looks for a clause.
An exception.
One last strategy.

That impulse is not necessarily rebellion.
It's customary.

We have solved everything like this in life.

And now we are facing something that does not give in to effort.

Finishes,
Not as an insult.
Not as a threat.
But as a recognition that each internal path has reached its limit.
There is no argument, no overlooked method, no hidden reserve capable of altering what exists or producing what is required.
Fulfillment is not despair.
It is the end of self-resolution.

If you've come this far feeling like there's nothing left to present, that's exactly the point Paul wants to get us to.

What to think about:

- In what ways do I usually compare myself to feel safe?
- Why does judging others produce a temporary sense of security?
- What kind of "advantages" have I entrusted to: morality, knowledge, discipline, religion?
- What happens when the law becomes a credential instead of a revelation?
- How does it feel to live without any favorable comparison points?
- Why is it so hard to accept that I have no advantage?
- What changes when every mouth is shut?

MOVEMENT 4 - GOD ACTS

(Romans 3:21-31)

Will there be a solution?

Are you still reading?

Are you still here?

What if I told you that there is a solution?

It is not a technique.

It is not a new discipline.

It is no other strategy than to try.

A solution.

After a silence that leaves everyone speechless, Paul introduces two words that change everything:

> *"But now..." - Romans 3:21*

But now.
These words do not simply mean "what follows." They indicate a change of direction.
So far, everything described belongs to a condition that cannot be resolved from within the human being. More effort, more discipline or greater sincerity do not alter the starting point. The problem was not a lack of intention; it was a lack of capacity.
And that hurts.
Because we all prefer that the problem is a lack of desire.
The desire can be increased.
Disability is not.
If the standard remains fixed, then the answer cannot emerge from the same place where the lack was born.
It must come from outside—and not only as help, but as complete sufficiency.
Paul does not present an improvement of the human system. Present an intervention. It does not say that justice was discovered, developed, or achieved. He says that **he has demonstrated.**
That means that it is not born from the human being. It already existed. It comes from God. And now it has been revealed.
If the problem were only behavior, a correction would have sufficed. If it were only ignorance, one teaching would have been enough. But Paul has shown something deeper: the person stands before God's truth without the ability to respond adequately. That is why the necessary justice cannot depend on those who need it. It must come entirely from outside.
Here the relief begins. Not because the standard has gone down,
but because sufficiency does not have to be manufactured. It has to be received.

The Answer is a Person

The answer is not an idea.

The answer is a person.

The sufficiency that has been described is not something that is built, learned, or earned.

It is found in Jesus Christ.

> *are justified… through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus… Romans 3:24*

This is where the direction becomes specific.
The problem was not only that something bad had been committed.
The problem was that he was facing God and couldn't get rid of it.
And the requirement was not partial improvement, but total alignment — something no one naturally possesses.
Christ is presented here not as an
inspiration, nor as an example to imitate,
nor as a religious symbol.
It is presented to him as sufficiency.

Christ is enough!

What He Did

The solution does not lie only in who Christ is.
It is also what Christ has done.
Trust is not placed in a figure in history or in a moral teacher.
Trust is placed in the One who acted.
It satisfied all the conditions we had as a lawsuit against us.
He did not limit himself to talking about forgiveness.
He brought redemption.
He didn't just describe reconciliation.
He made reconciliation possible.
That is why belief is reasonable.
It is not believing in a feeling.
It is the belief in a successful work.
The problem was facing God.
Resolution also comes from God.
Christ does not show up as an aid to help us finish the job.
He presents himself as the one who completed what we could not start.
The weight does not stay on the individual and receives a little help.

The weight changes hands completely.
That's why trust matters.
Not because trust creates the solution, but because trust
receives what has already been completed.
They're not asking you to be enough.
You are invited to trust in the sufficiency already provided in Christ—the One
and the work together.
Trust here is not admiration.
It is the full conviction in the sufficient solution of your critical situation with God provided in Christ.
This is not to say that Christ alone is important.
It is to recognize that Christ alone accomplished fully and satisfactorily what we could not.
Redemption is not a feeling.
It is a fair result, it is the solution.
The problem was real.
The record was real.
The requirement was real.
So the solution must also be real.
Christ did not come to suggest improvement.
He himself came to address the gap itself.
He did not come to encourage effort.
He came to provide what effort could never produce.
That is why the focus changes so completely.
You no longer try to balance what was opposed to you.
You trust the One who solved it.

> *... to him who does not work, but believes in Him who justifies the wicked, his faith is counted as righteousness. - Romans 4:5*

The load is shifted.
Not partially.
Completely.
You're not carrying most of the weight or getting help with the rest.
It's no longer you who carries the weight. You stop working, you no longer make an effort and you trust. You believe in the One who solved what was otherwise incurable.
This is what makes trust reasonable rather than emotional.
You don't trust a promise that depends on your strength.
You trust a finished work that doesn't depend on you holding it together.

And that's where sufficiency gets personal. Yours.
Not because you have become sufficient, but
because you now rest in the One who is.
When Christ is trusted, His sufficiency is no longer something to be observed from a distance. It gets personal. What He accomplished counts for you. The fit you couldn't produce is no longer something you try to achieve; It's something that now takes your place. The file that opposed you no longer corresponds to you, and the requirement that you could not meet no longer corresponds to you. Nothing is being ignored or pretended. The problem was real, and the solution is real. Its sufficiency is not an idea you cling to, it is a reality that now sustains you.
And that changes your standing before God now and always.

What to think about:

- What kind of justice would you need if you really couldn't produce it?
- What changes when justice appears from outside me?
- Why is it so tempting for me to reverse the order: first faith, then God's action?
- What are the implications of understanding justification as a verdict and not as a process?
- On what basis could God retract what He has declared?
- What happens to boasting when the action is completely divine?
- Have I turned faith into a refined form of merit?

MOVEMENT 4 (CONTINUED) - GOING BACK IN HISTORY

(Romans 4:1-25)
If God has declared something so decisive,
What is this verdict based on?
Can it really remain?
Or does it depend, in some way, on what happens next?
Paul doesn't leave these questions floating. He knows that an affirmation, no matter how profound, does not produce security on its own. Security is born when you understand **what that statement rests on**. That is why, in this movement, Paul does not add a new idea. It reinforces the previous one, showing that God's verdict is not fragile or recent, nor experimental.
To do so, Paul goes back in history.
Not to change the subject, nor to seek an inspiring illustration, but to show that **God has always acted in this way**. If the verdict were a recent innovation, it might seem shaky. But if it is consistent with the way God has worked from the beginning, then it rests on something much firmer.
That is why he introduces Abraham.
Abraham does not appear here as a moral hero or as a model of spiritual performance. Paul does not present him as someone who attained a higher level of obedience. In fact, his story — full of hesitation, wrong decisions, and moments of fear — would make him a bad candidate if the verdict depended on human performance.
And that's precisely the point. Abraham is not presented as someone who accomplished something, but as someone who achieved something.
as someone to whom **something was credited**. Paul deliberately uses accounting language:
counting,
impute,
accredit.
It is not a poetic language. He is technical. Crediting does not mean gradually transforming someone until they finally qualify. It means **to regard something as true by statement**.
Righteousness is not described as something Abraham produced, but as something that God chose to count as true about him.
This introduces a crucial distinction.
God does not wait for the inner reality of man to be perfect to pronounce His verdict. He pronounces the verdict to establish a new relational reality. If this were reversed—if God waited for human life to be sufficiently aligned—faith would be impossible. No one could expect to be "ready" to be declared righteous.
With this clear, Paul stops at faith itself, because he knows that here there is often another misunderstanding. Abraham's faith is not presented as admirable for its intensity, nor for its emotional constancy. It is not the volume of faith that matters, but **its object**.
Faith is not evaluated by looking inward, but by observing what it rests on.

Abraham did not trust in his future ability, nor in his progressive performance, nor in the improvement of his situation. He trusted God's word, even when his experience seemed to contradict it. Their faith was not in ignoring reality, but in leaning on God's promise over it.
Here it is worth pausing, because this point directly affects the reader's experience.
Many times we have measured our faith by observing ourselves: was it enough, was it firm, did I hesitate too much? When faith becomes introspective, it inevitably weakens. When it becomes objective – when it rests on promise – it can be sustained even in the midst of fragility.
Paul does not want the reader to admire Abraham's faith. He wants you to understand **how faith works**, so that you stop turning it into a new form of performance.
With this foundation in place, Paul moves on to one of the best-known—and most often misunderstood—statements of Romans: "*having been justified ... we have peace*."
The order here is decisive.
Peace is not the means by which justification is obtained. It is not something that is achieved first and then declared righteous. It is the result of a verdict already pronounced. And Paul does not present this peace, in the first place, as an internal emotion, but as an **objective condition**.
Peace
it begins in the relationship between God and the human being, not in the emotional state of the individual. The relationship has been resolved, even when the experience takes time to align with that reality.
This explains something that many believers experience without knowing how to explain it: there can be anxiety, doubts, or internal struggle, and still be at peace with God. Peace does not cease to be real because it is not always felt.
That is why Paul clarifies something important: peace does not mean the absence of internal conflict. It means absence of hostility. The fundamental conflict is over. God is not against it. You're not constantly evaluating. He's not waiting for something to go wrong.
When peace is understood as fragile, life is lived with caution. But when it is understood as declared, life can be breathed.
Paul reinforces this assurance with simple but forceful reasoning. If God acted when the human being was at his weakest, if he took the initiative when there was no merit, if he resolved the relationship when there was no possible answer... So,
On what basis could he now undo what he has already established?
This argument is not emotional. It is logical. God's action was not brought about by human improvement, therefore it cannot be nullified by human weakness. Here Paul introduces an idea that will run through all that follows:
security does not rest on the constancy of the believer, but on the coherence of God.
To close this movement, Paul uses another key term:
reconciliation.
He does not do this to describe a feeling, but an objective situation. Reconciliation is not the process by which man slowly returns to God. It is the act by which God **resolves the relationship**, and he does so while the human being cannot yet offer anything in return. This

ensures something fundamental: the relationship is not in a trial period. It is not subject to renegotiation. It is not pending future review.
With this move, Paul has closed another important door:
the idea that time, process, or experience could erode the verdict.
The verdict does not age, it does not adjust, and it does not become provisional. If it depended on time, it would never be safe. If it depended on performance, it would never be stable.
But it depends on God.
And that changes everything.
Now, with the verdict firmly established and assured, a new question arises—perhaps the most disturbing for many readers:
If the verdict is final, what place does sin now occupy? Does it still matter?, how is it related with this security?
Paul does not avoid that question.
That will be the next move.

What to think about:

- Where do I tend to support my confidence when my performance fluctuates?
- What is the difference between "accredited" and "transformed"?
- What do I look at when I evaluate my faith: in the promise or in my progress?
- Why can I have peace with God and still feel anxiety?
- What does it mean that peace is a condition rather than an emotion?
- If God acted when I couldn't respond, what could now undo His work?
- What really sustains my security: my constancy or God's consistency?

MOVEMENT 5 – STANDING, STANDING BEFORE GOD AS JUSTIFIED

(Romans 5:1-5:11)

What changed?

> *... having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ... we have gained entrance by faith into this grace in which we stand... Romans 5:1-2*

After affirming that God justifies, Paul does not immediately move on to practical life. It stops. And it does so for a very specific reason. When someone hears that God has pronounced a definitive verdict—that he has declared man righteous—a concern arises almost automatically. Not as a hostile objection, but as an honest question:
If God has declared something so decisive, can it really stand? Or does it depend, in some way, on what happens next?

A New Position

The standing position is now defined by what Christ accomplished, not by what a person fails to maintain.
The image of standing conveys more than just a physical posture. It evokes firmness, stability and balance. It speaks of someone who is not falling or staggering but upright, sustained and confident. That is why we chose this image: not to describe a body, but to illustrate a position. It is not about how someone looks on the outside, but about the reality in which they find themselves.
We speak of standing before God—a position of fixed status, not a movement. A position that does not depend on effort, but on what has already been established."

If Christ's sufficiency now counts for me, what really changed?
The answer is not just that something was forgiven.
Something was established.
Being "standing" before God speaks of location. It describes where a person now stands before God. This is not a feeling or a mentality. It is not optimism or motivation. It's a fact.
Through Christ, a new state of being became a reality. It was not formed gradually or offered conditionally. It was established decisively. This position does not depend on personal conscience.

It does not depend on the strength of the belief. It doesn't go up or down with performance. It exists because God made it so.
Christ's sufficiency not only offered help, it provided what was needed. What could not be produced personally was fully provided. For this reason, the standing before God is not partial, provisional, or yet to be completed. It is complete because the work that established it is complete. Our position does not change with mood, weakens with struggle, or disappears with failure. It remains because its source is not human resolution but divine action.
This is the reality: Christ's sufficiency has provided perfect standing before God. He set us on our feet, standing before God.
This position is not temporary. It is not a trial period. It's not something that gets better over time or weakens with difficulty. It was not formed by human effort, and it is not sustained by human effort. It is maintained because God established it.
What God establishes does not fluctuate according to circumstances. It doesn't adapt to the mood and doesn't back down when challenges appear. The basis of this position is not personal strength or consistency. Its basis is Christ and the work He completed.

Maybe your relationship with God feels like a bank account.

You add when you obey.
You subtract when you fail.

And every day you try to close in a positive way.

But many do not live that position like that.

Maybe your relationship with God feels like a bank account.
And you never know exactly what balance you're on.
That produces instability, not rest.

For this reason, the position of the justified is not fragile.
It does not need to be protected, defended or rebuilt after every failure.

It doesn't exist because you stand your ground.

It exists because its foundation remains.
A person may not fully understand this situation. A person may not even be aware of its depth. But the lack of awareness does not erase reality. The position does not appear when it is discovered, and it does not disappear when it is overlooked. It remains what it is because its origin is not human knowledge but divine action.

That is why the language of access becomes clear. The door does not open repeatedly. It has been opened. The relationship isn't waiting to start. It is already established. The position is not being negotiated. It has been granted.
Our position, then, is not movement. It's the location.
It's not effort. It's a fact.
He is not adapting. It is being.
This is what secured Christ's sufficiency: a real, present, and unchanging standing before God.
This means that standing up is not something a person goes in and out of. He does not sign up for good days and gets lost in difficult ones. It is not maintained with discipline, nor is it undone by inconsistency. It exists because its foundation exists.
The change that occurred was not cosmetic. It was not a change of attitude. It was not a "change of heart." It was a change of **position** before God. The relationship is no longer defined by distance or uncertainty. It is defined by what Christ assured.
None of this situation is imaginary. It is not positive thinking or spiritual optimism. It is the result of an action performed by God and completed in Christ. Whether it is fully understood or only partially, reality does not change.
That is why the language of access is direct. The path is not to reopen again and again. It has been opened.
We are therefore standing in a position of advantage, access and security, it does not speak of progress.
It's the location.
It is not striving.
It is reality.

A novel situation

Because this situation is real, life is no longer lived from uncertainty. The relationship with God is not negotiated day by day. It is already established. This changes the way a person approaches everyday life.
The difficulties do not disappear, but they no longer convey the same message. Difficulty is no longer interpreted as rejection, and struggle is no longer interpreted as distance. Circumstances may still be complicated, but they do not undo the position. The ground does not change every time life becomes unstable.
This does not eliminate responsibility or eliminate the consequences of daily decisions. What it eliminates is the constant fear that every failure will restart the relationship. To remain standing while living life. The base doesn't go up or down with performance.
From this position, where love has been poured out upon us, hope is born. Difficulties no longer stop us; they make us grow. Circumstances no longer define who we are.

In the same way that a person leans on a structure that is known to be solid, trust in Christ grows by recognizing that the foundation is secure. It is not a pressure to believe more strongly.
Life is no longer driven by the need to secure its belonging.
Belonging is now secure.
Dependence flows from reality, not fear.
The "standing before God" position came from the work of Christ.
Continued trust is simply living in light of that work.
Standing, then, is not something to be pursued or preserved. It is something that has already been established. Christ's sufficiency did not place a person on shaky ground; He established a firm stand before God. From that position, life is faced differently, not because circumstances disappear, but because the relationship no longer changes with them. Trust does not hold this position together; it simply rests on what already exists. Reality remains what God made it to be—safe, present, and unchanging.

MOVE 6 — SIN REPOSITIONED

(Romans 5:12-6:23)

Why Does Tension Persist?

After affirming that God's verdict stands, Paul knows that a question has already formed in the reader's mind. It is not a rebellious question. It is a logical theory. If God has declared it right, if the relationship has been reconciled, if peace has been established, why is there still a struggle?
Why do I keep sinning?
Why does desire conflict with intention?
Paul does not shy away from these questions. He anticipates them. And the way you respond is crucial to understanding everything that comes next.
Paul does not begin by minimizing sin. On the contrary, it broadens the perspective so that the reader can see it more clearly. That way you can see it well.
The struggle does not mean that the resolution was incomplete.
It means that life is now lived in a new reality that we are still learning to understand.
You may know this cycle:

Failures.
You feel guilty.
You make a silent promise: "Tomorrow yes."
And for a few hours you think this time will be different.

But he comes back.

And the guilt is heavier now, because you already promised.
It is not a lack of sincerity.

It's that you're trying to break a power by treating it only as behavior.

No one may know.

On the outside everything seems stable.
But there is a private battle that comes back again and again.
And exhaustion doesn't come from sin alone...

but to always try to control it.

I lived for years struggling with sins in my life. Many of them were very hidden from the people I ministered to as a missionary.

My life was a ring of fight against sin. I was focused on my enemy. My life became a management of sin.

Worst of all, it was discovering that, after all the effort, there was no victory.

Only cycles.

And that forced me to ask a deeper question:

What if the problem wasn't just what I was doing… but the place from where he lived?

Background Explanation

Enter Adam.
Not as an isolated moral figure, but as a representative head.

Through it, sin enters history not only as an act, but as a dominant condition.

Paul does not first present it as something that is done,
but as something under which one lives.

And that completely changes the diagnosis.

Because if sin were just a series of bad decisions,
a series of good decisions would be enough to solve it.

But Paul describes something deeper:

A reality that governs.
What a queen.
That exercises dominion.
And no one defeats a domain simply by promising better conduct.
This raises a key question:
Why do we continue to treat sin primarily as behavior, when Paul presents it as power?
As long as sin is seen only as behavior, the solution will always be effort.
But Paul is preparing the reader to understand why effort was never enough.

The Decisive Contrast: Adam and Christ

Paul does not present Christ as an improvement over Adam. It presents it as a new point of reference.

Just as humanity was defined by a reality that it did not consciously choose, it is now defined by another reality that it does not produce by itself. In both cases, the central issue is not individual action, but representative identification.

This challenges our usual way of thinking, because we prefer to believe that we are primarily defined by what we do. Pablo insists that we are first defined by the reality in which we are positioned.

What changes if the central problem is not "what I do", but "where do I live"?

This change in structure *alters everything*.

Grace does not respond to just one defect.

It responds to a complete condition.

Paul emphasizes something that should not be overlooked: grace is not a proportional reaction to sin. It's not a fine tuning. It is not a minimum compensation.

It is a decisive intervention.

Where sin once reigned, now grace reigns.

He does not compete. It has no balance. He rules.

> *just as sin reigned... even so, grace would reign... Romans 5:21*

This does not mean that sin is unreal. It means that it is no longer sovereign.

It's worth pausing here:

What if we took seriously the idea that sin no longer has the final say on our standing before God?

On what then would our persistent guilt be based?

Whence would our inner condemnation derive its authority?

The Inevitable Objection

At this point, Paul introduces the objection that many still raise today, though not always out loud:

If grace reigns, does it matter how we live?

Doesn't that open the door to indifference?

How Paul responds is decisive. It doesn't say, "It does matter, so be careful."

He does not abandon or retract grace.

It does not establish conditions. He states something even more radical:

That question shows that we do not understand the change that has occurred.

> *Shall we continue in sin—not at all... We have died to sin, how shall we still live in it? Romans 6:1-2*

Death and Life: Categories, Not Metaphors

Paul responds by redefining the terms.
He speaks of death and life not as sensations, but as objective realities. Dying to sin does not mean ceasing to experience temptation.
It means to stop living under their control.
Under his dominion.
This is where many readers get confused, because they are looking for an immediate experience that confirms the claim. But Paul does not first describe how he feels, but rather what he **is**.
What happens when we demand to feel a truth before accepting it as real?
The truth is still suspended.
Experience becomes the judge.
And rest never comes.
Paul reverses that order.

Identity Precedes Behavior

One of the most important movements in this passage is the order that Paul carefully maintains.
It doesn't say, "Leave sin to become something new."
He says, "You are something new; That is why sin no longer rules." The exhortation comes after the statement.
Behavior flows from identity.
Never the other way around.
Herein lies one of the great distortions of the Christian life:
To try to produce with effort what can only flow from an already established reality.
That causes burnout.
It produces chronic guilt.
It produces cycles of promises and failures.
Paul does not call for the struggle to obtain an identity.
It demands living according to a given identity.

Obedience Changes Nature

When sin ceases to be the master, obedience ceases to be survival.
It is no longer an attempt to avoid conviction.
It is no longer an effort to secure acceptance.

It is no longer a bargaining chip.

It becomes the answer.

Paul introduces a powerful image here: slavery. Not to instill fear, but to clarify an inevitable reality: we always serve something.

The question is not whether we serve, but whom.

And here's the amazing thing:

Serving justice does not mean losing freedom.

It is to live in tune with the reality that already defines us.

The Fruit Reveals Dominance

Paul does not use fear to motivate. Use results.

Ask the reader to observe sincerely:

What did sin produce when it ruled?

Penalty.

Guilt.

Death.

Fragmentation.

And then it shows the contrast:

When grace reigns, the fruit changes. Not because of external pressure, but because of their dominance.

This is a point that many believers should listen to calmly:

Fruit does not prove acceptance.

Reveal the source. It comes from the one who is exercising dominion.

Sin loses authority when it loses its place.

With this move, Paul is not teaching "how to overcome sin." It is doing something more fundamental: it is dethroning it. He has removed the authority of sin over us.

Sin no longer defines the relationship.

He no longer interprets identity.

It no longer determines the verdict.

> *... our old man was crucified with Christ, so that our body of sin might be destroyed... Romans 6:6*

Sin is still serious.

It is still harmful.

But it is no longer sovereign.

And this is where the title of the book resonates strongly:

"It is settled!"

Not because the believer has resolved his struggle, but because
God has already resolved the relationship.

So why Peco?

A new status doesn't automatically mean you stop sinning.
Many think that after salvation comes a life without sin or struggle. Or at least that is implied.
When they sin, they begin to doubt whether they were even saved in the first place.
When we begin to understand that as we learn to know and consider our new position, as we allow the power of the gospel to allow us to walk, we grow in Christ, we sin less.
So it's more about learning our new position and counting on it to bring us to maturity rather than focusing our thinking on how to handle our sin.
This is where the idea of "counting on what is real" becomes essential.

Trusting What's Real

That is why Scripture speaks of showing up.
It is not about gaining position.
The position is already established.
It is about what reality you allow to guide your decisions.
A person can stay safe before God and continue to live miserable if the attention never leaves the mentality of before. That misery does not come from a lack of legitimacy. He comes from living as if the old master still had authority.
Paul says, "We die to him."
It is not that sin has been annihilated.
The new position provides everything needed for the fullness of life.
But fullness is not found by managing sin.
You are resting in Christ and allowing His life in you to shape your daily life.
One should not try to live again trying to gain what Christ has already achieved. That is why the Christian life is by faith and not by counting our sins.

> *"BUT THE RIGHTEOUS SHALL LIVE BY FAITH." - Romans 1:17*

This does not mean that sin is insignificant, it means that Christ is the sufficient solution to sin. We live in light of His adequacy and not trying to live in the deception of self-righteousness by striving not to sin.

Change is not imposed.
It is recognized.
Life changes when what is already true is finally treated as truth.

What to think about:

- Have I treated sin primarily as conduct or as power?
- What changes when the central problem is "under what reality do I live"?
- Why am I uncomfortable with the idea of an identity that precedes behavior?
- In what ways have I tried to produce with effort what can only flow from grace?
- What authority does guilt have in my life today?
- What is the difference between sin being present and ruling?
- What does it mean to obey when it is no longer to ensure acceptance?

MOVEMENT 7 — THE LAW TO LIVE

(Romans 7)

The wrong fuel

Another question arises at this point.
If standing is real and the struggle is still happening, why is it sometimes so hard to do the right thing?

The problem is usually not a lack of knowledge.
Most people know what to do.
The problem is the inability to carry it out.

> *"... Because the will is present in me, but the doing of good is not." Romans 7:18*

This is where many turn to motivation.
"Don't give up."
"Try harder."
"Do your best."

When that motivation wears off, a common source of fuel is guilt.
And where the fault is most easily found is in the law.

Maybe you never miss a meeting.
You read your Bible.
You serve faithfully.

But you live under constant evaluation.

When you have a good spiritual day, you breathe.
When you fail, you shrink.

Your peace rises and falls with your performance.

That is not a lack of commitment.
It is living under measurement.

The law is clear.
Draw boundaries.
It exposes what is wrong.

It makes a person aware of failure.

And that awareness easily turns into pressure.

Guilt becomes fuel... until the fuel runs out.
Your peace rises and falls with your performance.
And that's exhausting.
But guilt is a weak motivator. It produces effort for a moment, then frustration,
Then exhaustion.

> *... But when the commandment came, sin was revived, and I died. Romans 7:9*

The law was never given to be an engine for daily life. It reveals what is right, but it does not provide the strength to live it.

Two Cycles

Using the law as motivation often creates a cycle.
A person realizes what is wrong, feels guilty, tries harder, fails, and then feels guilty again.
Sometimes the cycle is different.
Conscience leads to guilt, guilt to effort, effort to temporary success—and success becomes pride.
Neither path produces the life God intended. In both cases the standard becomes clearer, but the ability to meet it does not increase.
This is not because the law is bad. It is because the law was never meant to be the source of life.
Something else happened when our standing before God was established.
A person is not only given a new position before God.
They are also transferred **under a new authority**.

> *... We have obtained entry... to this grace in which we stand... Romans 5:2*

The law no longer has authority as a motivator, but we have been positioned (stand) under grace to be our teacher. Titus 2:11-12

A New Authority

Grace does not use guilt as fuel.
It works differently.

It provides a stronger reason to live rightly and the ability to do so.
This is not effort-based performance.
It is dependence on the sufficiency of Christ.
It is life driven by faith rather than pressure.
Whenever a person tries to move forward into life out of guilt, they often end up condemning themselves and reverting to the same old patterns they were trying to escape.
The struggle increases, not because nothing has changed, but because the wrong source of motivation is being used.
The position is real.
The disposition is real.
But guilt doesn't fit with the kingdom to which Christ brought you.
Life in Him was never designed to run with condemnation. It was designed to work gracefully.
Grace is not passive.
He is an effective coach and motivator.
Where the law demanded what was right but could not produce it, grace provides both the reason and the strength to live it.
The problem was not knowing what the standard was. The problem was the lack of power to deal with it.

What to think about:

- What do I really expect the law to do in my life?
- How do I distinguish between moral enlightenment and actual ability?
- Have I interpreted internal conflict as identity rather than as the wrong system?
- What has living under the law as an operative principle produced for me?
- When is spiritual exhaustion a sign of lack of surrender... and when is it a sign of bad tool?
- Why is the right question not "what should I do," but "who can deliver"?
- What changes when the law ceases to govern?

MOVEMENT 8 — LIFE LIVED WITH POWER

(Romans 8)

There is no more condemnation

Now there is no condemnation

This is not because the standard has disappeared or the past has been ignored. It is because Christ provided what the law could never provide. The law could point out what was right. I could expose what was wrong. But it could not produce life. He could describe fate, but he couldn't move a person toward him.

> For God's sake.
>
> *For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death. Romans 8:2*
>
> That is why the gospel message is described as the power of God. It is not simply information about forgiveness. It's not inspiration to encourage a better effort. It's power — the kind that really changes the way life is lived.

What once depended on pressure and self-motivation now flows from another source. The engine has changed. The life that follows is not driven by guilt or fear, but by the presence and power of God Himself at work within you.

Life and Peace

This is not abstract language. It is the practical reality. Life in the Spirit is simply life lived with a new source of strength. The mindset in this direction begins to experience something constant and unexpected: life and peace. Not because the challenges disappear, but because the base no longer moves with them.

Peace here is not the absence of difficulty.

It is the presence of alignment.

Daily life still contains decisions, responsibilities and difficulties. But they no longer get along on their own or feed on exhaustion. The same power that secured the position now provides strength to live from that state. What was once impossible with effort becomes possible through provision.

Present Struggle, Future Completion

Life does not become painless. The world suddenly doesn't cooperate. However, suffering no longer conveys the same message as it once did. It is no longer interpreted as rejection or distance. It becomes part of a larger story that is moving towards completion.

The future is not described as uncertainty, but as glory—not exaggeration, but fulfillment. What began with Christ does not stop halfway. It continues towards its intended end. The current tension is no longer a dead end; It becomes part of the process moving forward.

Nothing separates

> The final guarantee is simple and constant.
>
> *I am convinced that [nothing] will be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus Christ our Lord. Romans 8:38-39*
>
> Nothing separates a person from the love of God in Christ.

It is not a difficulty.

It did not fail.

Not fear.

It is not a circumstance.

This is not an emotional mood to lift the spirits. It is an affirmation about the relationship. The bond does not depend on personal strength. It remains because Christ remains. The same sufficiency that established the legitimation also maintains the connection.

Chapter 8 is not idealistic thinking at the cloud level. It's real life on dry land. The gospel is not just the gateway to relationship; It is the power that drives that relationship day by day. What began as a resolution becomes a lived experience. Force replaces tension. Peace replaces pressure. Hope replaces uncertainty.

Life is no longer an attempt to achieve what is right.

It becomes participation in what has already been provided.

Nothing—no circumstance, no failure, no power, no visible or invisible force—has the authority to separate us from God's love in Christ. What was established through Him does not loosen over time, weaken with struggle, and do not crumble under pressure. The relationship is not based on human strength, but on divine action already completed. This is not optimism or desire. It is a settled reality. The same God who established the position sustains it, and nothing in creation has the power to reverse what He has done.

What to think about:

- What authority do my feelings have in the face of "no condemnation"?
- Do I live as if the Spirit were help or as if it were a source?
- What does it mean to live from adoption and not from evaluation?
- How do I interpret suffering: as a threat or as part of a larger story?
- Where do I look for security when words are no longer enough?
- What things have I allowed to try to reopen a case that God has already closed?
- What would a life truly live from rest look like?

FINAL CHAPTER — HISTORICAL PROOF

(Romans 9-11)

The Broadest Evidence

At this point a question naturally arises.
And what about Israel?
God gave them promises.
They were chosen to be their nation.
They were entrusted with revelation.

> *And yet, history shows repeated failures. And I will make you a great nation, and I will bless you, and I will make your name great; And so you will be a blessing; - Genesis 12:2*

At first glance, it may seem that the promises were not kept.
It may seem that human failure canceled out divine intent.
Some even conclude that God took back what He once declared.
But that conclusion doesn't match the big picture.
Israel's history is not a history of promises made and then erased.
It is a story of promises preserved despite human incoherence.
There were consequences.
There were seasons of distance.
There were national and personal failures.
But the promises themselves did not dissolve.
This distinction is important.
Human response influenced the experience.
It did not annul what God established.
What God declared did not disappear when people faltered.
It remained, often carried out through corrections, restorations, and time.
Israel becomes proof of a greater truth:
God's faithfulness is not fragile.
It is not undone by human weakness.
The pattern observed in Israel is not abandonment; it is persistence. Not of men, but of God.
Failure brought discipline, but discipline did not equate to rejection.
The delay did not amount to cancellation.
Correction does not equate to reversal.
The promises were not recovered.
They were maintained.

And that is why Israel matters in this discussion.
His story shows, at the national level, what has already been said on a personal level:
What God establishes, He sustains. Human inconsistency affects the journey, but it does not change the destination.
This is not selective memory.
It is observable history.
The same faithfulness that preserved God's purposes with Israel is the faithfulness that secures what has been established in Christ.
Evidence is not abstract.
It is written over generations.
This broader view eliminates a common misunderstanding.
Israel's history is not proof that God changes His mind.
It is proof that he does not.
There were times when the road became difficult, times when people moved away, periods marked by loss and exile.
However, even in those seasons, the foundation did not disappear.
What God had said did not dissolve with circumstances.

Promises Kept

> *For I do not want you, brethren, to be unaware of this mystery—lest you be wise in your own estimation—that Israel has had a partial hardening until the fullness of the Gentiles has come;* ***and so all Israel will be saved****; As it is written, "THE DELIVERER WILL COME FROM ZION, HE WILL TAKE AWAY THE WICKEDNESS OF JACOB. THIS IS MY COVENANT WITH THEM, WHEN I TAKE AWAY THEIR SINS." - ROMANS 11:25-27*

The promises were not fragile agreements waiting to be broken.
They were statements rooted in God's own character.
And its character does not fluctuate as human determination does.
Looking at Israel across generations reveals a consistent pattern.
The human response goes up and down.
God's faithfulness does not.
From this angle, Israel is no exception to the message — it is a confirmation of it.
The same principle seen throughout centuries of history is the principle already seen in the personal position: what God establishes, he does not withdraw.
In the end, what does all this mean?

It means that the relationship with God is not built on personal strength, personal consistency, or personal effort. It is based on what God has already done through Christ. The established position is not a fragile arrangement that must be maintained day after day. It is a reality created by God and sustained by Him.

It also means that struggle, failure, and delay don't have the final say. They affect experience, but they do not revoke what has been established. Just as the history of Israel shows that God's purposes endure beyond human inconsistency, personal life shows the same pattern. The journey may contain difficulties, but the foundation remains.

This does not eliminate the responsibility or importance of daily decisions. It eliminates fear as a driving force. Life is no longer an attempt to secure your belonging. It becomes the unfolding of the belonging already granted. Trust grows not because the pressure increases, but because stability becomes visible.

What you can take home is simple and consistent:

God's faithfulness is greater than human weakness.

The sufficiency of Christ is greater than the personal fault.

God's love is not temporary, and His purposes are not easily reversed.

The message is not that life becomes effortless.

The message is that life is no longer lived alone or uncertain.

The ground under the relationship does not change.

God keeps His promises not because human beings keep them, but because He has committed Himself to them.

This reinforces everything that is said in Romans 1–8.

If God has proven himself faithful in the historical context, why wouldn't he also be faithful on a personal level?

If he has not reversed his purposes over generations, why would he do so now with those whom he has justified?

Christian security is not naïve, it is historical.

The Christian faith does not rest on a fragile hope or on an optimistic interpretation of life. Rest in a God whose faithfulness can be tested over time.

Israel is not a side note.

It is the visible testimony that God does not abandon what he has declared.

Therefore, Romans 8 is not the emotional climax of the letter, but its logical conclusion.

And Romans 9–11 does not contradict it; He endures it.

The verdict stands because God stands.

The reader can conclude this journey with a deeper certainty than at the beginning. Not because he knows himself better now, but because he now knows God better.

A God who: He begins what He promises, He stands firm in what He says and fulfills what He has decided. That is why the Christian life can be lived without fear of revocation. Not because the believer is constant, but because God is.

The Final Word

History does not reopen the case.

He confirms it.

Thus, at the end of Romans 1–8—backed up by the history of Israel—the reader need add nothing, clarify nothing, or assert anything.

You can only claim, with complete confidence:

It is settled!

It Is Settled is coherent and internally consistent. Its strength lies in never rushing conclusions. Rather than announcing answers, it walks the reader toward recognition.

What the reader can expect:

- A consistent voice—calm, reasoned, and never preachy.
- A clear logical progression from Romans 1–8, confirmed in 9–11.
- Precision without theological jargon.
- A repeated "quiet realization" motif that leads to clarity.
- An ending that lands with certainty but without emotion.

It Is Settled is a brief read, yet dense with clarity—presenting powerful truths in clear, understandable language.